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FAR EASTERN DEPARTMENT

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FROM Parliamentary Question
Mr. Teeling.

No. 46

Dated 16th. May 1949

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Transfer of surplus population and industries of Hong Kong to Formosa.

Mr. Teeling asked the Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs if he would reconsider the position of Formosa under the Cairo Agreement in order that the surplus population of Hong Kong may be transferred there. Mr. Bevin replied that he would not,

Last Paper

FM 1188

References

(Minutes)

Copy to Washington, Embassy Office Canton, and Tokyo.

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9) Canton Emb Office 5
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Next Paper

F 4257

Far Eastern

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Parliamentary Question 102

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* M. Mr. Teeling,—To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs, whether, in view of recent happenings in China, His Majesty's Government will reconsider the position of Formosa under the Cairo Agreement in order that the surplus population and industries of Hong Kong may be transferred there. [*Monday 16th May.*]

Brighton

ANSWERED 16 MAY 1949
REPLY ATTACHED.

Mr. Teeling asked questions about Formosa on the 2nd March (Flag A) and the 9th March (Flag B). The following brief statement of the position regarding Formosa, reproduced here for convenience of reference, was submitted with the draft replies to both previous questions.

The island was internationally recognised as being under Japanese sovereignty before the war. At Cairo on the 1st December, 1943 President Roosevelt, Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek and Mr. Churchill declared "that all the territories that Japan has stolen from the Chinese such as Manchuria, Formosa, and the Pescadores shall be restored to the Republic of China". The Heads of the Governments of the United States, United Kingdom and China reaffirmed that "the terms of the Cairo Declaration shall be carried out" in the Potsdam Declaration issued on the 26th July, 1945. The Potsdam Proclamation was subsequently adhered to by the Soviet Union. When Japan surrendered she accepted the Potsdam Proclamation and surrendered, in fact, to the four Potsdam Powers. It was as a result of agreement among these Powers that General MacArthur was appointed to be Supreme Commander for the Allied Powers "for the purpose of enforcing the surrender of Japan", and it was on the basis of a directive agreed upon by the same four Powers that Japanese forces in Formosa were eventually instructed to surrender to Chiang Kai-shek. A Chinese Military Administration was thereupon set up in Formosa and subsequently superseded by a Chinese Civil Administration which is still in existence. Thus the Chinese, in view of the Cairo Declaration, appear to have been permitted to assume the administration of Formosa (which is legally still under Japanese sovereignty) without there being any very precise international agreement on the subject. We are aware that the Americans are at present showing great interest in the future of Formosa and that some American circles think it desirable that Formosa should be withheld from the Chinese Communists. But American intentions are not yet clarified and we clearly do not wish to be drawn into any speculation on possible future developments.

Mr. Teeling's suggestion that the "surplus population and industries of Hong

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Kong" should be transferred to Formosa is, to put it bluntly, remarkably stupid. Formosa is already seriously overcrowded with refugees from the Chinese mainland. H.M.G. have no special position in the island and are not seeking one. In any case ~~the~~ population and industries have moved to Hong Kong because of the relatively high standard of law and order there, and because of the various special transport and other facilities which have been built up in the island during long years of British rule. A similar situation does not exist in Formosa.

Draft reply submitted. (Colonial Office concur.)

F. S. Tomlinson
F. S. Tomlinson
11th May, 1949.

We are justified I think in treating this silly question a bit roughly.

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FORMOSA

46. **Mr. Teeling** asked the Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs whether, in view of recent happenings in China, His Majesty's Government will reconsider the position of Formosa under the Cairo Agreement in order that the surplus population and industries of Hong Kong may be transferred there.

Mr. Bevin: No, Sir.

Mr. Teeling: Does the right hon. Gentleman realise that Formosa was actually offered to Britain in 1895 before the Japanese took it over? Does he further realise that Hong Kong cannot go on absorbing the Chinese and others, and if these people want the protection of the British why not allow them to have it in Formosa?

Mr. Bevin: I think my predecessor in 1905 was a very wise statesman in not taking it over.

Mr. Teeling: Eighteen ninety-five.

Mr. Bevin: In 1895 then. I confess I have not looked it up. I hope I am keeping up the tradition of the Foreign Office in being as wise now. I cannot agree with the hon. Member in the proposal which he now makes.

Mr. Gallacher: In view of recent happenings in China, would the right hon. Gentleman consider taking the very sensible step of making direct diplomatic contact with the liberation forces in China, and then there would be no need to worry about Formosa?

Mr. Teeling: Does the right hon. Gentleman realise that his reply to me suggests that he is not taking the question of Formosa very seriously? It is not handed back yet to China and there is likely to be great trouble about it in the near future.

Mr. Bevin: I have given serious consideration to Formosa, and I think the hon. Gentleman's Question was rather startling. In reply to the hon. Member for West Fife (Mr. Gallacher), I do not think what he asked has anything to do with the Question.

16 MAY 1949

✱ 46. Mr. Teeling,—To ask the Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs, whether, in view of recent happenings in China, His Majesty's Government will reconsider the position of Formosa under the Cairo Agreement in order that the surplus population and industries of Hong Kong may be transferred there.

Draft Reply to P.Q.
No. +17
Mr. Teeling
16th May, 1949.

No, Sir.

Notes for Supplementaries

1. Mr. Teeling may press for fuller consideration of his suggestion about the transfer of surplus population and industries from Hong Kong to Formosa. Mr. Teeling appears to be suggesting that Formosa should be placed under some form of British administration; but his suggestion is both frivolous and obscure and scarcely deserves serious consideration. The reply might be:

"The implications of the honourable Member's suggestion are so startling that I cannot really think that he intends it to be taken seriously".

2. If Mr. Teeling presses his suggestion that some steps should be taken to change the present status of Formosa, the reply might be:

"I have nothing to add to the reply which my right honourable Friend the Minister of State gave to the honourable Member on the 14th March."